John’s Revelation

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Introducing the New Testament (Carson & Moo)

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Life Application Bible Commentary (B. Barton)

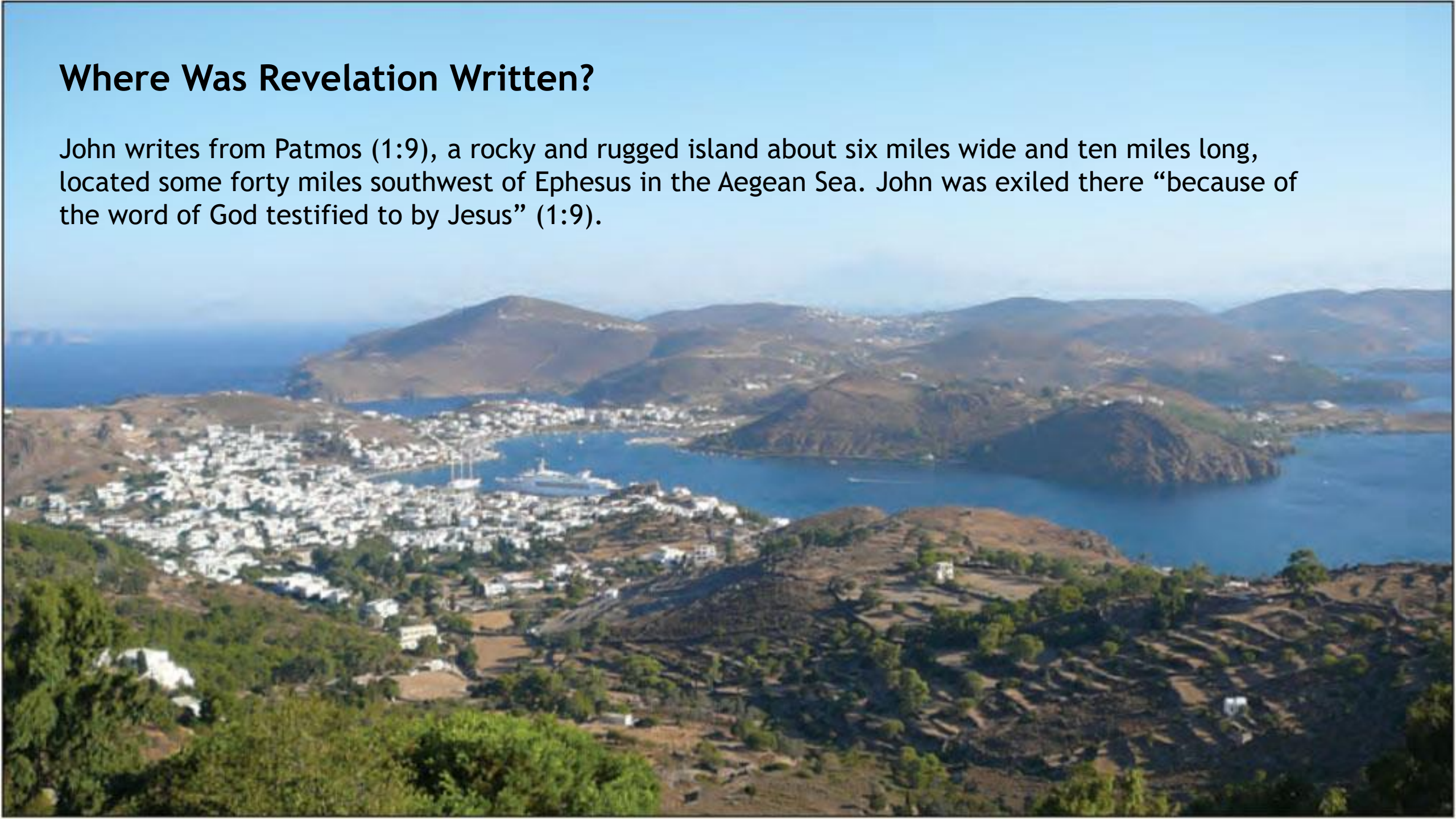
John’s Revelation

Who Wrote Revelation?

Revelation claims to have been written by “John, your brother and companion in the suffering and kingdom and patient endurance that are ours in Jesus” (1:9; also 1:1, 4; 22:8). He makes no other claims about himself, which suggests that he was well known to his readers. Which John would have been better known to the churches of Asia Minor in the late first century other than John the apostle? Reliable early church tradition, which places the apostle John in Ephesus at the end of his life, testifies that he wrote Revelation (cf. Justin, Irenaeus, and Polycarp).

Where Was Revelation Written?

John writes from Patmos (1:9), a rocky and rugged island about six miles wide and ten miles long, located some forty miles southwest of Ephesus in the Aegean Sea. John was exiled there “because of the word of God testified to by Jesus” (1:9).



John’s Revelation

When Was Revelation Written?

The two most likely options for dating Revelation are either shortly after the Emperor Nero’s reign (A.D. 54–68; cf. Rev.17:10) or at the end of the Emperor Domitian’s reign (A.D. 81–96). The oldest tradition holds to the latter (specifically the years 95–96), because the conditions generally presumed in Revelation are more likely to have existed during Domitian’s reign:

- Emperor worship was an issue for Christians (13:4, 15–16; 14:9–11; 16:2; 19:20; 20:4), and Domitian ordered that he be addressed as “lord and god” (cf. 4:11), apparently making this confession a test of loyalty.
- The letters to the seven churches are much more compatible with a date in the A.D. 90s than one in the 60s. For example, the city of Laodicea was destroyed by an earthquake in 60–61, yet the Laodicean church of Revelation is wealthy; a date in the 90s would give plenty of time for such recovery. Additionally, the church at Smyrna may not even have existed until 60–64.

John’s Revelation

To Whom and Why Was Revelation Written?

- John directs the record of his visions to seven churches in the Roman province of Asia. John probably knew these churches from his years of ministry in the area, and all of them were located in cities that were centres of communication.
- John’s reason for selecting these seven churches, as well as the order in which they are listed, probably has to do with geography and communications. As William Ramsay pointed out long ago, the cities in which the churches are located are all centres of communication; a messenger bearing Revelation to the cities would arrive from Patmos in Ephesus, travel by secondary road north to Smyrna and Pergamum, and then go east on the Roman road to Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea.

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ASIA
Aegean Sea
Pergamum
Thyatira
Sardis
Smyrna
Philadelphia
CHIOS
Ephesus
SAMOS
Laodicea
Miletus
PATMOS
LYCIA
KOS
Cnidus
Patara
Rhodes
RHODES
Mediterranean Sea
CRETE
0 50 km.
0 50 mi.
• Seven churches of Revelation 1–3

John’s Revelation

What Style of Literature Is Revelation?

Revelation combines elements of apocalypse (1:1), prophecy (1:3), and letter (1:4) in a complex way that has no close parallel in other literature. Therefore, we should not neatly label it as only one style of literature.

- **Apocalypse:** Revelation is not pure apocalypse because it is not pseudonymous and it grounds hope in Jesus’ past sacrifice rather than a future event. General characteristics of apocalypse include the following: revelatory visions within a narrative framework; symbolic, figurative, and metaphoric language; and interpret present, earthly circumstances in light of supernatural, heavenly realities and the future.

John’s Revelation

What Style of Literature Is Revelation?

- **Prophecy:** Revelation is not only apocalyptic in form, but it is also prophetic. It is prophetic both by forthtelling (e.g., 1:8) and foretelling (see 1:19, “write … what will take place later”). Prophecy style is distinguished from apocalyptic by its more positive tone (repentance will forestall judgment) and its spoken nature (1:8; 22:12–13, 16, 20). Apocalyptic style tends to be more negative in tone (not much hope in the present, yet future vindication and judgment are certain) and it is more visionary in form (*LBD*).
- **Letter:** Revelation is a circular letter to seven churches in Asia Minor (1:4–5, 9–11). It possesses a typical epistolary greeting formula (1:4–5, “John to the seven churches … Grace and peace”) and the entire book climaxes in a brief postscript (22:21), which is characteristic of other New Testament letters. However, its content and style are not similar to typical letters.

John’s Revelation

What Are the Major Approaches to Interpreting Revelation?

Interpretations of Revelation typically fall under four approaches:

- **Preterist:** John’s visions grow out of and describe events in his own day. Those events are now *past* (hence, the label “preterist”). The symbols in the visions all refer to people, countries, and events in the world of John’s day, and his purpose is to exhort his readers to remain faithful to Christ as they wait for God to deliver them into his eternal kingdom.
- **Historical:** Revelation sketches history from the time of Christ to our own day. The focus tends to be on Western church history. This interpretation was common in the Middle Ages and with the Reformers, who identified the beast with the papacy.

John’s Revelation

What Are the Major Approaches to Interpreting Revelation?

- **Idealist:** Revelation symbolically depicts the ongoing conflict between the forces of God and of Satan throughout the church age. As such, the symbols can have multiple fulfilments.
- **Futurist:** A consistently futurist approach holds that everything in Revelation 4–22 will be fulfilled in the very last days of human history. A more moderate form holds that some events of chapters 4–22 (particularly the earlier ones) have occurred already or will occur before the very end.

John’s Revelation

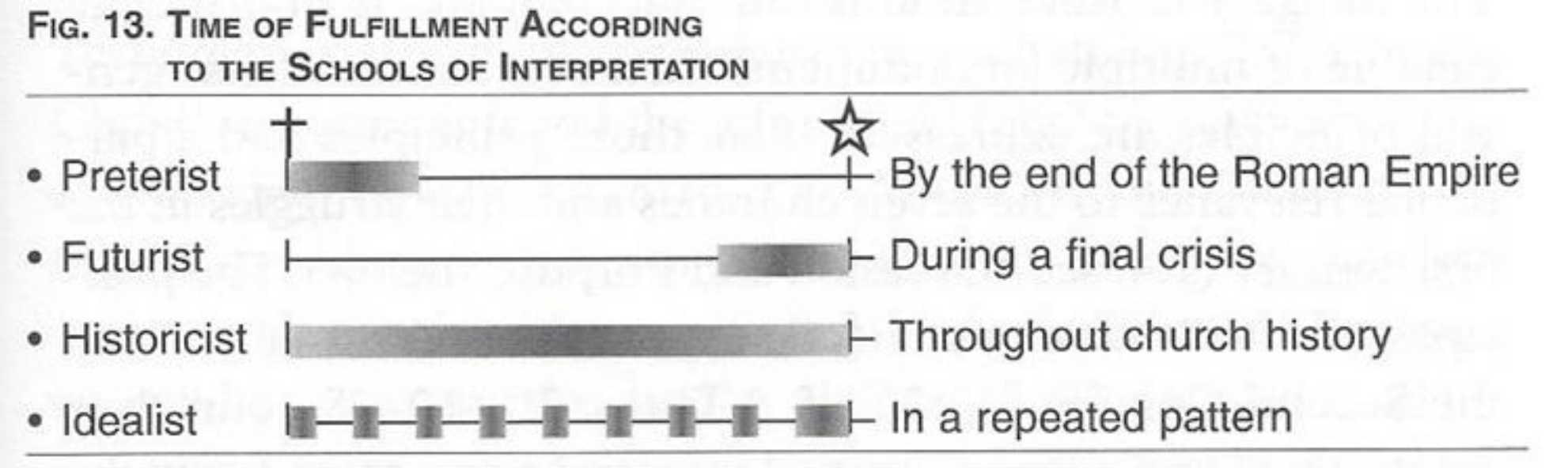
Interpretive Approaches to Revelation

Preterist	Fulfilled entirely or mainly in the first century
Historicist	Fulfilled in stages throughout church history
Idealist	Fundamentally symbolic
Futurist	Fulfilled mainly in future

(Schreiner)

John's Revelation

What Are the Major Approaches to Interpreting Revelation?



Pros and cons of each approach: Preterism doesn't make good sense of all the details of the book. The Historicist understanding would be meaningless (unintelligible) and irrelevant to John's original audience, so too the Futurist approach. The Idealist approach could be too vague to be helpful at times.

John’s Revelation

What Are the Major Approaches to Interpreting Revelation?

- Many readers argue for **a mixed or eclectic approach** that combines key insights from futurism, preterism, and idealism.
  - **Preterists** are probably correct that the whole book addresses the circumstances of John’s first-century readers.
  - **Idealists** rightly affirm that Revelation has ongoing relevance throughout history and that John’s symbolic visions may have multiple fulfilments.
  - **Futurists** correctly stress that Jesus will return to judge evil, save God’s people, and establish God’s everlasting kingdom.

John’s Revelation

The Do’s and Don’ts of Interpreting the Book of Revelation

- The book must be interpreted like any other book of the Bible (cf. historical, literary and redemptive-historical contexts)
- The genre is important = letter/prophecy/apocalyptic
- Keep the ‘big picture’ of the book in view; don’t get ‘lost’ in the details.
- Interpret the book in a way that is harmonious with the rest of Scripture. Allow the simple and straightforward parts of Scripture to interpret the complex and difficult (cf. Rev.20).
- Interpret the symbolism through the ‘eyes’ of the original readers and its Old Testament background.
- Keep Christ centre-stage, not an eschatological time-table.
- The book is intended to bless those who read, hear and obey its teaching (cf. Rev.1:3). Keep this ‘lens’ in view as you read the book.

John’s Revelation

Interpreting Symbolism in the Book of Revelation

Recognizing the predominant symbolic genre of Revelation is crucial as we approach the interpretation of the book.

We can assume that there are four levels of communication in most segments of Revelation, especially from **ch.4** and onward:

- the linguistic level, which is composed of the record of the text itself to be read or heard;
- a visionary level, which consists of John’s actual visionary experience;
- a referential level, which consists of the particular historical identification of the objects seen in the vision;
- and a symbolic level, which consists of what the symbols in the vision connote about their historical referents (cf. the beast; the Lamb).

(Beale)

John's Revelation

SELF-INTERPRETED SYMBOLS IN REVELATION

REFERENCE	SYMBOL	REVELATION'S INTERPRETATION
1:20	seven stars	angels
1:20	seven lampstands	churches
4:5	seven lamps	God's spirits
5:6	Lamb's seven horns, eyes	God's spirits
5:8	golden bowls	prayers of God's people
7:13–14	white-robed multitude	believers out of the great tribulation
11:4	two olive trees, lampstands	witnesses
14:3–4	the 144,000	undefiled followers of the Lamb
17:9–10	beast's seven heads	hills (Rome), kings
19:8	fine linen	righteous acts of God's people
20:5	thousand-year reign	first resurrection
20:14	lake of fire	second death

(NIVZSB)

John’s Revelation

The Structure of Revelation

- **Threefold Structure Based on 1:19**

  I. What You Have Seen (1:1-20)

  II. What Is Now (2:1-3:21)

  III. What Will Take Place Later (4:1-22:21)

- **Fourfold Structure Based on "In the Spirit" Experiences**

  I. In the Spirit on the Island of Patmos 1:9-10)

  II. In the Spirit in Heaven (4:1-2)

  III. In the Spirit in a Desert 17:3)

  IV. In the Spirit on a Mountain (21:10)

(Charts on Revelation)

John’s Revelation

The Structure of Revelation

- **Chiastic Structure**

A Prologue and Greeting 1:1-8)

B Seven Churches (1:4-4:2)

C Seven Seals (3:21-8:5)

D Seven Trumpets-Angels-Two Witnesses (8:2-11:19)
E Woman, Dragon, and Male Child (12:1-17)
D' Two Beasts-Angels-Seven Bowls 03:1-16:21)

C' Destruction of Babylon (16:18-19:10)

B' New Jerusalem, the Bride 09:6-22:9)

A' Closing and Epilogue (22:6-21)

(Charts on Revelation)

John’s Revelation

The Structure of Revelation

- **Sevenfold Drama Structure**

  Prologue 1: 1-8)

  Act 1 The Seven Golden Lampstands 1:9-3:22)

  Act 2 The Seven Seals (4:1-8:4)

  Act 3 The Seven Trumpets (8:5-11:18)

  Act 4 The Seven Tableaux (11:19-15:4)

  Act 5 The Seven Bowls of Wrath 15:5-16:21)

  Act 6 The Seven Judgments 17:1-20:3)

  Act 7 The Seven Great Promises (20:4-22:5)

  Epilogue (22:6-21)

(Charts on Revelation)

John’s Revelation

The Structure of Revelation

- Revelation has a recursive structure (= ‘recapitulation’ [Hendriksen]). In other words, the book often comes to the end of history (e.g., 6:12–17; 7:15–17; 11:15–19; 14:1–5, 14–20; 16:17–21) and begins again.
- Hence, the book isn’t like most epistles, with a logical structure that is unfolded. Nor is it a linear book like Genesis, which proceeds in chronological order.
- Interestingly, though the genre is entirely different, the book in some ways reminds us of 1 John, in which John articulates themes and then circles back to reflect on them again, continuing this method throughout the letter.

(Schreiner)

John's Revelation

A Simplified Structure of Revelation

chs. 1–3	Letters to the seven churches
chs. 4–5	Throne room vision
chs. 6–7	Seven seals
chs. 8–11	Seven trumpets
chs. 12–14	Visions of heaven and earth
chs. 15–16	Seven bowls
17:1–19:10	The fall of Babylon
19:11–22:21	The consummation and the new heaven and new earth

(Schreiner)

John’s Revelation

‘Interludes’ in Revelation

6:1–8:1 - The seal judgments

- 7:1–17 - First interlude: God’s people protected on earth and celebrating in heaven

8:2–11:19 - The trumpet judgments

- 10:1–11:13 - Second interlude: John’s role as prophet and the church’s role as witness
- 12:1–14:20 - Third interlude: The cosmic war between God and the forces of evil

15:1–16:21 - The bowl judgments

(Duvall)

The Book of Revelation

An Overview of Revelation

- In chapter one, John relates the circumstances that led to the writing of this book (1:1-20). In chapters two and three, Jesus gives special messages to the seven churches of Asia Minor (2:1-3:22).
- Suddenly John is caught up into heaven, where he sees a vision of God Almighty on his throne. All of Christ's followers and the heavenly angels are worshiping God (4:1-11). John watches as God gives a scroll with seven seals to the worthy Lamb, Jesus Christ, (5:1-14).

The Book of Revelation

- The Lamb begins to open the seals one by one. As each seal is opened, a new vision appears. As the first four seals are opened, riders appear on horses of different colors - war, famine, disease, and death are in their path (6:1-8). As the fifth seal is opened, John sees those in heaven who have been martyred for their faith in Christ (6:9-11).
- A set of contrasting images appears at the opening of the sixth seal. On one side, there is a huge earthquake, stars falling from the sky, and the sky rolling up like a scroll (6:12-17). On the other side, multitudes are before the great throne, worshiping and praising God and the Lamb (7:1-17).

The Book of Revelation

- Finally, the seventh seal is opened (8:1-5), unveiling a series of God's judgments announced by seven angels with seven trumpets. The first four angels bring hail, fire, a burning mountain, and a falling star-the sun and moon are darkened (8:6-13). The fifth trumpet announces the coming of locusts with the power to sting (9:1-12). The sixth trumpet heralds the coming of an army of warriors on horses (9:13-21).
- In chapter 10:1-11, John is given a little scroll to eat. Following this, John is commanded to measure the temple of God (11:1-2). He sees two witnesses who proclaim God's judgment on the earth for three and a half years (11:3-14).

The Book of Revelation

- Finally, the seventh trumpet sounds, calling the rival forces of good and evil to the final battle. On one side is Satan and his forces; on the other side stands Jesus Christ with his forces (11:15-13:18).
- In the midst of this call to battle, John sees three angels announcing the final judgment (14:6-13). Two angels begin to reap this harvest of judgment on the earth (14:14-20).

The Book of Revelation

- Following on the heels of these two angels are seven more angels who pour out God's judgment on the earth from seven bowls (15:1-16:21).
- One of these angels from the group of seven reveals to John a vision of a "great prostitute" called Babylon (symbolizing the Roman empire) riding a scarlet beast (17:1-18). After the defeat of Babylon (18:1-24), a great multitude in heaven shouts praise to God for his mighty victory (19:1-10).

The Book of Revelation

- The final three chapters of the book of Revelation catalogue the events that finalize Christ's victory over the enemy: Satan's 1,000-year imprisonment (20:1-10), the final judgment (20:11-15), and the creation of a new earth and a new Jerusalem (21:1-22:6).
- An angel then gives John final instructions concerning the visions John has seen and what to do once he has written them all down (22:7-11).

The Book of Revelation

- Revelation concludes with the promise of Christ's soon return, an offer to drink of the water of life that flows through the great street of the new Jerusalem, and a warning to those who read the book (22:12-21). May we pray with John, "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus" (22:20).
- The Bible ends with a message of warning and hope for men and women of every generation. Christ is victorious, and all evil has been done away with. As you read the book of Revelation, marvel at God's grace in the salvation of the saints and his power over the evil forces of Satan, and remember the hope of this victory to come.

The Book of Revelation

What Does Revelation Contribute to Our Understanding of the Faith?